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Assignment 1066

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IARCO RESEARCH PROPOSAL

Full Legal Name: Thu Htet Han

Institution: IIP International School

Category: Junior

Class/Grade/Year: O Level

Country: Myanmar

Submission Date: September 30, 2025

Registered Email Address: thuhtethun@gmail.com

Research Topic: Social Science

Title: Scam Callers and the Elderly: Analyzing Financial Stress, Psychological Strain, and Vulnerability

Research Question

1. To what extent does financial loss from scams exacerbate psychological trauma, victim shame, and depressive symptoms among older adults?
2. How do pre-existing mental health conditions, such as late-life depression (LLD), influence both an elderly individual's vulnerability to fraud and their subsequent recovery?

Introduction

Each year, over $1 trillion is lost to fraud globally [1]. Transnational criminal syndicates exploit political instability, enforcement gaps, and low digital literacy to build scam compounds across vulnerable regions worldwide. Despite global efforts to crack down on these networks, new operations continue to emerge at an alarming rate [2].

Older adults are disproportionately targeted by these fraudsters, making financial exploitation one of the most frequent forms of criminal victimization the elderly experience. Beyond direct economic loss, fraud inflicts severe, long-term damage on victims with acute mental health crises, persistent self-blame, and overall well-being. Thousands of elderly victims face the complete erasure of their life savings, with some suffering severe health crises or loss of life due to the immense strain [3]. To bridge this gap, this paper investigates elderly vulnerability to telecommunication fraud and its resulting psychosocial toll, evaluating how financial loss leads to acute mental health crises, persistent self-blame, and a loss of personal independence.

Literature Review:

The Mechanism of Telecommunication Fraud and Impersonation Tactics

Studies show that impersonation is the most common form of telecommunication fraud targeting older demographics. In "grandparent scams," fraudsters impersonate an elderly individual's grandchild or relative who claims to be in urgent crisis, leveraging high-stress scenarios to induce panic and bypass critical decision-making [3]. Modern advances in technology have amplified this threat; bad actors increasingly employ generative Artificial Intelligence (AI) to create synthetic voice clones, video, and imagery of recognizable family members to heighten psychological coercion [4]. Furthermore, advancements in Artificial Intelligence (AI) enable real-time voice and video impersonation of close family members, executives, or other trusted figures, fabricating high-stress scenarios that demand immediate financial transfers [5].

Psychological Vulnerability Factors and Late-life Depression

Mental health and cognitive well-being directly correlate with an older adult's susceptibility to telecommunication fraud. Research indicates that elderly individuals who

maintain strong physical and mental health are significantly less vulnerable to deceptive tactics employed by fraudsters. Older adults with mild cognitive conditions, which are linked to financial incapacity, including arithmetic abilities, executive functioning, and verbal memory, and psychological conditions such as late-life depression (LLD), have been shown to directly increase an older adult's risk of fraud victimization [6][7]. Additionally, gaps in fraud awareness, low digital literacy, and difficulty screening suspicious information increase vulnerability among older demographics. Research indicates that many seniors overestimate their financial knowledge, maintaining overconfidence in their choices even when exposed to deceptive tactics [3].

The Financial and Mental Health Consequences of Victimization

Fraud victimization often inflicts severe harm on an older adult's physical and psychological health. Because many victims are retired or live on a fixed income, recovering from these financial and physical setbacks introduces a significant challenge [8]. Financial instability among older adults can lead to profound psychological harm, including heightened stress and depression. Over time, these economic setbacks compromise personal independence, drive social isolation, and threaten the victim's basic human rights and dignity [9]. Beyond financial setbacks, studies suggest older adults suffer declines in confidence, increased rate of depression, and a greater risk of fraud victimization in the future [8]. Estimated losses per victim range from $1,000 to $2 million, and many older adults fall victim to fraud on more than one occasion [10].

Policies to Prevent Fraud

Financial exploitation and common fraud continue to occur as societal structural issues exert an ongoing negative impact. Even once detected, authorities within a given legal jurisdiction are often unsure how to proceed, as fraud typically spans multiple jurisdictions. Most professionals who encounter financial exploitation are not trained in this area, rendering them unable to identify the abuse or take actionable measures against it [8].

Methodology:

A. Research Design and Conceptual Framework

This study will adopt a systematic, multi-perspective approach to evaluate how fraud impacts the psychological health and vulnerability of older adults. The framework combines quantitative measurements of financial loss with qualitative metrics of mental health outcomes. By correlating the technical mechanics of scams with existing cognitive and psychological baselines, the research analyzes both pre-existing susceptibility factors and post-victimization trauma.

B. Data Collection and Search Strategy

To answer the core research questions without direct clinical intervention, a secondary data analysis and systematic literature extraction protocol were conducted across peer-reviewed databases (e.g., IEEE Xplore, PubMed, PsycINFO, and JSTOR) and institutional reports (e.g., INTERPOL, Consumer Financial Protection Bureau).

Target Demographic: Adults aged 60 and older who have been exposed to or impacted by telecommunication fraud.

Keywords & Search Strings: Boolean queries combining terms such as "elder fraud", "voice cloning" and "psychological strain".

Inclusion Criteria: Studies published between 2016 and 2026 focusing on financial exploitation, cognitive capacity, LLD, and psychological post-trauma in older populations.

C. Variable Measurement and Analytical Variables

The study evaluates three primary clusters of variables:

1. **Financial Impact Variables:** Monetary loss magnitude (categorized from $1,000 to $2,000,000+) and percentage of net life savings lost.

2. **Psychological & Clinical Variables**: Pre-existing Late-Life Depression (LLD), perceived loss of autonomy, self-reported shame, and depressive symptom severity following loss.

3. **Fraud Mechanics**: Modality of attack (standard impersonation vs. generative AI synthetic voice/video cloning)

D. Synthesis and Data Analysis

Data extracted from selected empirical studies and case histories are synthesized using thematic qualitative analysis and cross-study comparative synthesis. The analysis evaluates:

Direct Effects: The quantitative relationship between total monetary loss and the severity of post-victimization psychological strain.

Moderating Effects: How pre-existing conditions like Late-Life Depression (LLD), social isolation, and cognitive decline accelerate vulnerability and impede post-fraud emotional recovery.

Systemic Gaps: The efficacy of current legal, law enforcement, and institutional responses across jurisdictional boundaries in mitigating victim trauma.

E. Limitation

Victim Reluctance: Telecommunication fraud against the elderly is severely underreported due to victim shame, fear of losing independence, and a lack of digital literacy. Furthermore, victims often choose not to report fraud out of fear that relatives will look down on them or deem them cognitively impaired, further heightening their fear of losing financial autonomy.

Cognitive Impairment and Consent: As age increases, memory retention among older adults frequently decreases. Consequently, elderly individuals with cognitive impairment or memory loss may not fully recall the details of a fraud incident, or they may forget the event entirely. Therefore, it increases the complexity in data collection and the impact of post-fraud victimization.

F. Ethical Consideration

This study relies on secondary data analysis, ensuring no direct risk or psychological harm to the victims. Because this study focuses on a sensitive topic, it will adhere to principles of responsible disclosure, emphasizing the protection of vulnerable older demographics with mental health conditions.

Conclusion

Telecommunication fraud against older adults is a humanitarian concern where cybercrime, mental health, and policy gaps intertwine. Financial loss from scams inflicts severe psychosocial harm, causing late-life depression, acute trauma, and loss of personal autonomy. Pre-existing cognitive vulnerabilities further heighten susceptibility. Overcoming this crisis requires closing the gap between technological defenses, specialized legal frameworks, and trauma-informed support to safeguard the financial security of elderly populations.

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